

Water Buckets to World Records

Preetismita Bhoi's odyssey to the podiums

What are the odds of someone running 100 and 200m sprint events in their school, getting spotted by a coach who asks them if they would like to switch to weightlifting and then going on to write a tale of grit and glory in Odisha's weightlifting history? All of this seems possible today, if one takes a look at Odisha's weightlifter, Preetismita Bhoi.

Born in Odisha's Dhenkanal, 16-year-old Bhoi has been dominating headlines recently with a new World Record under her name in clean and jerk in the 44kg category in the 3rd Asian Youth Games, Bahrain, by lifting 92 kgs. She has emerged as the new weightlifting prodigy from India, setting new standards on her way to global podiums. However, her story has not always been filled with stories of victory but has traversed through several trysts, trials and tribulations.

Coming from humble beginnings, Bhoi lost her father at a tender age. She and her sister Bidusmita Bhoi (weightlifter and Commonwealth gold medalist) were raised by their mother, Jamuna.

When her coach Gopal Krushna Das found her 11-year-old self in tears for finishing second in sprinting, at her school's annual sports meet, he noticed her deep love for sports. While she had readily agreed to switch to weightlifting, her mother firmly refused. 'It took me six months to convince Preetismita's mother to let her become a weightlifter. She was concerned and feared for her child,' shares Das.

But the attempts to convince finally paid off when her mother asked her to fill water buckets and walk for 30 metres, at her coach's insistence. That marked the beginning of her weightlifting journey in 2019.



She began her training in 2020 at the District Indoor Stadium in Dhenkanal under coach Das. In 2022, she was inducted into the Odisha Weightlifting High Performance Centre (HPC) at the Dhenkanal Sub-Centre. Owing to her remarkable performances at national-level competitions, she transitioned to the National Centre of Excellence (NCOE), Patiala, in 2023.

After a series of hits and misses, the world took notice when Preetismita created a world record in clean & jerk in 40kg category, by lifting 76kg In the 2024 IWF World Youth Championships and scripted history as the first Indian to win a world title. She was awarded the prestigious PM Rashtriya Bal Puraskar by President Smt. Droupadi Murmu for this historic feat last year. Preetismita was inducted into the Target Olympics Podium Scheme (TOPS), earlier this year.

She has also won a gold medal in the Commonwealth Weightlifting Championships 2025 held in Ahmedabad. With weightlifting in her heart and weights in her arms, she wishes to win the elusive Olympic medal for India one day.